

Fleet Street 1700's

No. 143

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

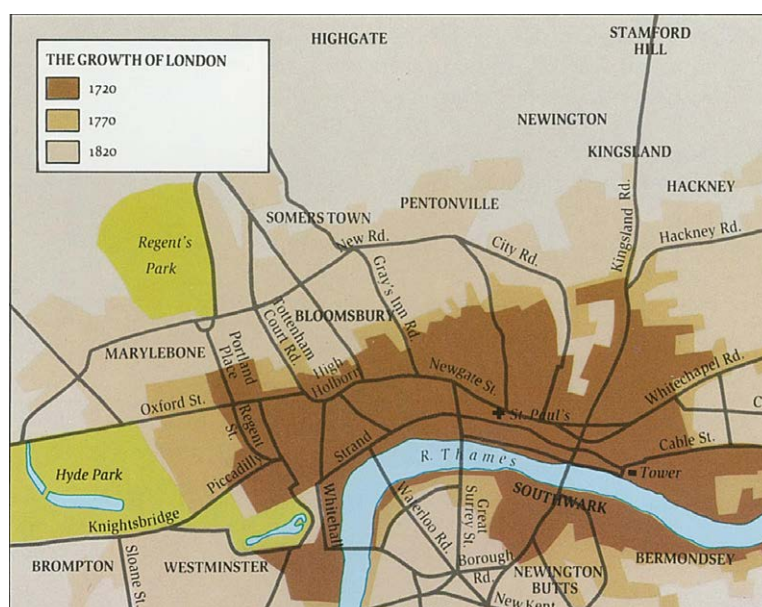
April 2026

Important events in 18th-century Fleet Street included the publication of Britain's first daily newspaper, the Daily Courant, in 1702, and the completion of St Paul's Cathedral in 1710.

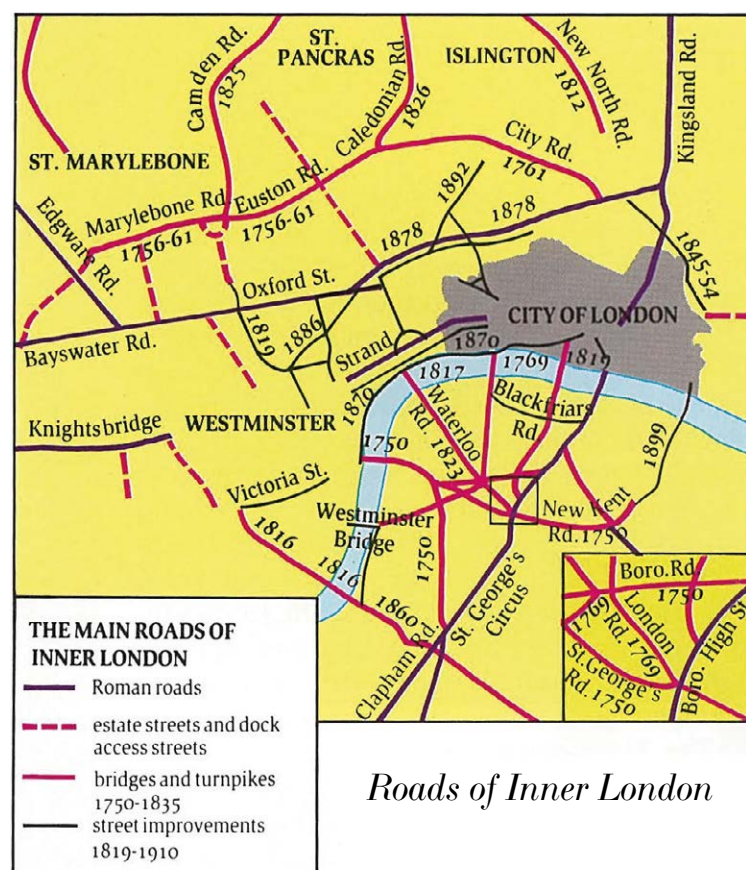
The Fleet River continued to silt up despite dredging by Christopher Wren and Robert Hooke. In 1736 it was covered over and the Fleet Market built above it. South of Fleet Street lay Alsatia, or the "Liberty of the Fleet", a law-free district known for instant marriages.

London's growing population expanded Smithfield Market, while improved roads, turnpikes and the Penny Post made travel and communication faster, helping trade and newspaper circulation.

The illustrations show London's rapid growth between 1720 and 1820, and the network of new bridges and turnpike roads built alongside the city's ancient Roman roads.



Growth in the 1700's



Roads of Inner London